

## **In the Name of God, the Most Beneficent, the Most Merciful**

First of all, I would like to extend my courtesy to all the honorable participants in this webinar, ladies, and gentlemen, and I wish that, just like earlier efforts, this effort of the Cultural Center of the Islamic Republic of Iran in Mumbai would promote and strengthen coexistence among the followers of different religions and human societies, especially the people and government of India and the people and government of Iran.

I also plead to God Almighty to free the people of the world from this annoying virus so that travels, visits, and meetings could return to their normal state.

Religious and ethnic diversity do not only constitute the indicators of the growth of a nation but are also important factors in the human and evolutionary growth of humanity.

Today, a society like India can be introduced as a good model for peaceful coexistence in which the followers of different religions like Hinduism, Buddhism, Sikhism, Jainism, and Christianity live together in complete peace under various circumstances.

Of course, wherever there is a problem, that problem is not because of the differences between religions, but it is the outcome of corrupt and tyrannical seditionist policies that can be quickly and effectively confronted and thwarted through the wisdom of religious and political leaders and people's rationality.

It is in the Islamic teaching of ours that:

“O mankind! Be wary of your Lord who created you from a single soul, and created its mate from it, and, from the two of them, scattered numerous men and women. Be wary of Allah, in whose Name you

adjoin one another and the wombs. Indeed, Allah is watchful over you.”

According to this teaching, all human beings are from one single soul and no one is superior to others in their humanness, and all of them are brothers and sisters and there is no bond higher than the bond of brotherhood.

Hence, we must protect religious diversity. Let us put together the common concepts and stand together because violating this stance would create difficult conditions.

Our future is the same, so we must support our diversity, freedom, and standing by each other.

We cannot support diversity without accepting the freedom of the other side and in the absence of giving others the right to choose their religion, and this will not happen except by strengthening a system for preventing the greed of the enemies. Therefore, a nation that fails to support its land, interests, and wealth will not be able to support diversity, too.

We emphasize supporting religious diversity in the East because we are all aboard one ship, that is, the ship of humanity, so we must take care of each other in order to reach the shore of salvation.

Of course, a life of diversity is worthy of human beings, because according to our religious teachings and the existing reality, human beings are the loftiest of beings and, therefore, deserve the best of lives.

According to the Holy Quran:

“Certainly We have honored the Children of Adam, and carried them over land and sea, and provided them with all the good things, and

given them an advantage over many of those We have created with a complete preference. (Surah Al-Isra, Verse 70)

Today, in the Islamic Republic of Iran, we look at every Iranian as a fellow-citizen, and there is no difference between a Muslim, a Christian, a Jew, a Zoroastrian, or a Sabians. We, together and in spite of our communal diversity, form the most peaceful land in the region as a country and the threats received in the past few decades have not created any hindrance to our solidarity, which is becoming stronger day by day.

The Center for Interreligious and Inter-Cultural Dialogue holds more than 40 dialogues with religions and countries around the world annually; right from the Vatican to India. All these dialogues, along with other religious and cultural dialogues, which are held around the world and by different religions and countries, have had good results for human society.

In recent decades we have witnessed meetings between leaders of different religions, some of which have led to fraternity agreements and plans for fostering coexistence among nations and/or followers of different religions. While endorsing such movements we believe that these meetings and interreligious dialogues should increase day by day, because dialogues cause result in knowing each other, increasing compassion and affection, and removing doubts between the leaders and followers of different religions.

Unfortunately, the big powers admit that they have spent thousands of billions of dollars in recent wars, which, of course, have had no results except massacre and homelessness for humanity, and increasing the gap between nations and religions. It is important to know that biased propaganda groups seek to introduce these wars as the outcome of

religious and doctrinal differences, whereas we all know that different religions share common messages and human values.

All religions, with no exception, seek peace, security, justice, brotherhood, and the spread of compassion and friendship and helping one another to achieve a great human civilization that is worthy of the human being who considers himself to be the vicegerent of God Almighty on the earth; the God of the universe who emphasizes such teachings such as mercy, philanthropy, and striving for perfection, and considers all human beings as His family, and everyone who serves this family more is closer to His court.

If today's political rulers would spend a fraction of what is being spent on wars and weapons of mass destruction, chemical and nuclear and classical weapons, on dialogues and resolving the material and spiritual problems of the people of the world, the human world would be in a much better situation today.

Looking forward to the expansion of friendship and brotherhood, I pray that this meeting and webinar would be of great divine blessing for human society.

With warmest regards

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